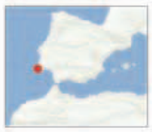
SEVEN YEARS WAR

LAGOS BAY

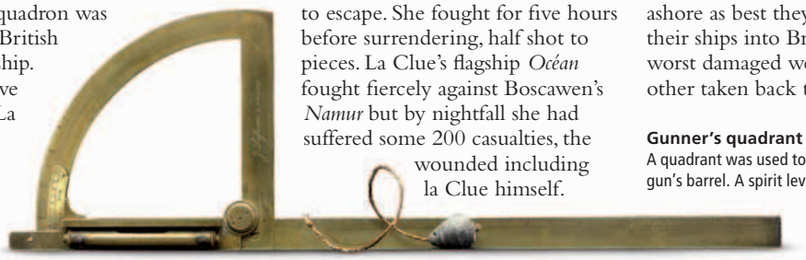


Date August 18–19, 1759
Forces British: 14 ships of the line; French: 7 ships of the line
Losses British: none; French: 3 ships of the line destroyed, 2 ships of the line captured

Location Off the Algarve, Portugal

In the summer of 1759 France was preparing for an invasion of Britain. Admiral Jean-François de la Clue-Sabran was ordered to bring the French Mediterranean fleet from Toulon to join the Atlantic fleet at Brest. The combined force would then escort troops to landing places in Scotland and England. A British squadron under Admiral Edward Boscawen was maintaining a blockade of Toulon, but in late July Boscawen was forced to sail to Gibraltar to refit damaged ships and take on supplies. La Clue seized the opportunity to set sail with 12 ships of the line on August 5.

Reaching Gibraltar on August 17, the French squadron was spotted by a British observation ship. Boscawen gave chase while La Clue raced through the night into the Atlantic. Daybreak revealed that the French squadron had become divided, only seven ships remaining with their admiral while the others made for Cadiz. Boscawen had ordered a general pursuit and his ships engaged the enemy as they came up. The 74-gun *Centaure*, in the French rear, attempted to hold off the pursuit and give the other French ships a chance to escape. She fought for five hours before surrendering, half shot to pieces. La Clue's flagship *Océan* fought fiercely against Boscawen's *Namur* but by nightfall she had suffered some 200 casualties, the wounded including la Clue himself. During the night two French ships escaped, dawn revealing the remainder at Boscawen's mercy. La Clue sailed the remnant of his squadron into a bay to the west of Lagos in neutral Portugal, hoping that a shore battery might scare the British off. But Boscawen followed the French into the bay regardless and opened fire. The French crews got ashore as best they could, abandoning their ships into British hands. The three worst damaged were set ablaze and the other taken back to Gibraltar as a prize.



Gunner's quadrant
A quadrant was used to determine the elevation of a gun's barrel. A spirit level attached to the pivot arm marked the horizontal, while a plumb-bob measured the required angle.

1704–1759

JOHN BYNG

BRITISH ADMIRAL

John Byng was the son of a distinguished admiral, Viscount Torrington. He made comfortable peacetime progress in a naval career, progressing from lieutenant at age 19 to rear admiral in his 40s. Byng had never held command in battle before being sent into action against the French at Minorca in 1756. His withdrawal to Gibraltar after that indecisive encounter led to a court-martial. The British navy's Articles of War obliged officers to do their utmost to engage the enemy, which Byng had failed to do. He was found guilty, the offence carrying a mandatory death penalty. The court recommended royal clemency, which was normal when men of high birth were condemned to execution. However, the loss of Minorca had caused a popular outcry in Britain, and a scapegoat was needed. Byng was executed by firing squad on the quarter-deck of the ship of the line *Monarch* at Portsmouth on March 14, 1757.

CREW PROFILE

SHIP OF THE LINE

1700–1800

THE MAJORITY OF THE CREW of an 18th-century Royal Navy ship of the line were ordinary seamen and able seamen, the latter being trained up to skilled tasks such as working aloft or steering the ship. Sailors usually first went to sea as boys—it was believed that a grown man could never learn to work high above the deck without dying in the attempt. In peacetime naval vessels were manned largely by volunteers, but in wartime sailors had to be pressed into naval service from merchant vessels or other maritime occupations. Though subject to harsh discipline, seamen on a well-run ship would feel a bonded part of a skilled team, and, in battle, would enthusiastically man the guns or take up arms to repel boarders.

WARRANT OFFICERS

The master, although still a significant figure on the ship, had lost importance compared with a century earlier, because commissioned officers were now trained in seamanship and rivaled the master for knowledge of navigation and sailing. The purser and the surgeon were the other warrant officers of wardroom rank. Below them came the boatswain, carpenter, sailmaker, and gunner, solid characters of lower-class origin traditionally attached to a single ship in which they served for long periods. They were sometimes unofficially allowed their wives on board.

COMMISSIONED OFFICERS

Although in the Royal Navy progress from warrant officer or even able seaman to commissioned rank was not unknown, officers were usually gentlemen. The sons of socially respectable families were taken into naval service as boys, usually recommended to a captain by a relative or family friend. When old enough they became midshipmen, hoping to pass the examination required for appointment as lieutenant, probably after six years at sea. The next step was to be made post-captain, with command of their own ship, after which promotion to admiral was strictly by seniority. A captain's authority was absolute, although his own behavior was subject to the Articles of War.



Gun crew at battle stations
Each gun was manned by up to six sailors. A gunner was in charge of all cannons, while a quarter gunner was in charge of four.